

**THE LONG ODDS**

Written by

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FADE IN:

**INT. MERIDIAN AUTO BODY - GARAGE BAY - NIGHT**

Rain hammers a corrugated roof. Sparks fall from a welding torch.

DESMOND HALE, 40s, grease to the elbows, kills the torch and lifts his mask. Behind him, a wall calendar from ZENITH MOTORS hangs crooked, the logo faded.

A radio in the corner plays "Sweet Child O' Mine" through static.

DESMOND

You're three weeks late, Marty.

MARTY OKONKWO, 30s, jittery, stands in the doorway holding a soaked paper bag.

MARTY

I got most of it.

DESMOND

Most of it isn't it.

Marty sets the bag down. A can of Coca-Cola rolls out and comes to rest against Desmond's boot.

MARTY

There's a guy. Buys salvage titles, doesn't ask questions. Pays in cash.

DESMOND

There's always a guy.

MARTY

This one's real. Calls himself Cortland. Runs it out of the old Delaney building on 1247 Wabash.

Desmond wipes his hands. Says nothing.

CUT TO:

**INT. DESMOND'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS**

A cramped room. A television bolted high in the corner plays a scene from THE GODFATHER, sound off.

Desmond drops into a chair. On the desk: a copy of the CHICAGO TRIBUNE, folded to the business section.

He picks up a landline and dials.

DESMOND  
(into phone)  
Yeah. It's Hale. Put me through to  
the claims desk.  
(beat)  
No, the direct line. 312-664-9920.

He waits. On the wall behind him hangs a print of Edward  
Hopper's NIGHTHAWKS, the frame cracked.

DESMOND (CONT'D)  
Tell Vandermeer at STATE FARM I  
want the file on the Kessler wreck.

CUT TO:

**EXT. WABASH AVENUE - NIGHT**

A black sedan idles at the curb. Illinois plate: KJ-4471.

CORTLAND VOSS, 50s, expensive coat, steps out. He checks a  
phone, then the building.

CORTLAND  
(into phone)  
Send it to voss@zenithmotors.com.  
Tonight.

He pockets the phone and goes inside.

CUT TO:

**INT. DELANEY BUILDING - FREIGHT ELEVATOR - CONTINUOUS**

Cortland rides up. Fluorescent light stutters.

He unfolds a printout. The header reads NORTHWESTERN  
MEMORIAL HOSPITAL. Below it, a name: DR. ALAN REINHOLT,  
CARDIOLOGY.

CORTLAND  
(to himself)  
Four signatures. That's all this  
is.

CUT TO:

**INT. DELANEY BUILDING - FOURTH FLOOR - NIGHT**

An open floor. Filing boxes. Two men wait: BRICK, huge, and a YOUNGER MAN at a laptop.

YOUNGER MAN  
Site's up. Registered it this  
morning. midwestsalvageauth.com.  
Looks official enough.

CORTLAND  
It doesn't need to look official.  
It needs to look boring.

Brick laughs. Cortland doesn't.

CORTLAND (CONT'D)  
The Reinholt signature. How close?

YOUNGER MAN  
Close.

CORTLAND  
Close is what put Kessler in the  
ground.

The Younger Man stops typing.

CUT TO:

**INT. MERIDIAN AUTO BODY - GARAGE BAY - LATER**

Desmond stands over an engine block, not working. Marty watches him.

MARTY  
You're gonna do something stupid.

DESMOND  
I'm gonna do something slow.

He pulls a cardboard box from under the bench. Inside: manila folders, decades of them.

DESMOND (CONT'D)  
Eleven cars. Same adjuster, same  
doctor, same signature. Six years.

MARTY  
Why'd you keep 'em?

DESMOND  
Because I knew I'd need them and I  
hoped I wouldn't.

He sets one folder aside. On the tab, in marker: KESSLER.

4.

FADE OUT.

END OF EXCERPT